

Abortion Access and Institutional Demand for Higher Education: Evidence from *Dobbs v. Jackson Women's Health Organization**

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Abstract

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1 Introduction

On June 24, 2022, the Supreme Court decided *Dobbs v. Jackson Women's Health Organization*, returning abortion policy to the states and ending the federal protection the Court had recognized in *Roe v. Wade* nearly fifty years earlier. Within six months, thirteen states enacted abortion bans that would remain for at least the next two years. Twelve additional states saw delays in their bans or adopted more limited restrictions that were enjoined, reversed, or never rose to a total ban. The result is the sharpest change in the geography of American abortion access in half a century.

This paper asks how that change propagated into the market for four-year undergraduate education. The question is well-posed for three reasons. First, women aged 15-24 (the age group for which future or current college decisions is most pertinent) make up about 37% of all abortions in the U.S. ([Kortsmitt et al., 2023](#)). Second, the college choice decision has an inherent state policy environment component as the prospective student weighs living there for the better part of four, perhaps more, years. Third, the timing of the application, admission, and enrollment cycle creates a sharp empirical discontinuity: students applying for fall 2022 admission faced a set of institutions for whom many saw dramatic changes in abortion access in their states, while others experienced no such change. To the extent that students care about this issue, we expect to see impacts to where they decide to go to school.

Whether and how institutional demand would respond to changing abortion access is, ex ante, ambiguous. For instance, if abortion access is simply a health care amenity that students consume, either directly via receiving an abortion or indirectly as one might "consume" insurance, while enrolled, then bans should reduce demand at institutions in ban states. If instead state-level policy functions as a signal of the political identity of the local community, then the direction of the demand response depends on the composition of potential students. A ban repels applicants who oppose it, attracts those who favor it, and the net effect at any given institution would then depend on which group is numerically larger in the relevant draw. Survey evidence we review in the background section establishes that both stories have empirical support among the college-age population: the majority of women of reproductive age support legal abortion and would prefer to attend college in a state with greater access, but a meaningful minority prefers the opposite. Furthermore, there is evidence to suggest that the political views of other students is an important determinant in their college decision. Estimating which direction wins, and at which kinds of institutions, is an empirical question.

We are aware of two papers that have taken up pieces of this question in a much more limited scope. [Walker et al. \(2023\)](#) use Common Data Set applicant counts from seventy-one of the top-100 US News institutions and find a roughly one-percentage-point decline in the female share of applications at ban-state schools for the 2022-23 school year, concentrated among the top fifty institutions which draw a disproportionately large share of out-of-state applicants. They are explicit that their findings "are driven by the top 50 ranked universities whose applicants often have multiple educational options and it is unlikely that these results extended beyond these institutions for the fall 2022 freshman cohort." [Kane \(2025\)](#) uses restricted Common App individual-level application data and a difference-in-differences design comparing high-achieving female students to high-achieving male students, and estimates a 2.7-percentage-point decline in the probability that a high-achieving woman applies to a ban state. However, this analysis focuses on a subset of students for whom effects may not easily generalize to the universe of college hopefuls. Although

both papers identify effects at the application margin, we seek to broaden the scope of our research beyond applications and beyond elite institutions and students.

We begin with the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS) universe of four-year public and private not-for-profit institutions for school years 2010-2011 through 2024-2025. After imposing data restrictions to be discussed in Section 4, we are left with 894 institutions which are home to roughly 5.5 million undergraduates (2021). We use this sample to estimate institution-level demand responses to the *Dobbs* decision in terms of applications, admissions, enrollment, composition, retention, and published tuition. Our design is a two-way fixed-effects event study in which institutions in persistent-ban states (total or six-week gestational bans in effect throughout 2022, 2023, and 2024) are the treated group and institutions in never-ban states, states with no such restriction and not designated hostile to abortion access in December 2022, are the controls. We drop the dozen intermediate-intensity “hostile” states because their policy environments are neither a clean treatment nor a clean control.

Given the proximity of the *Dobbs* decision to the heterogeneous state-level impacts of and responses to Covid-19 (Dave et al., 2021; White and Hébert-Dufresne, 2020), we employ 2019 as our reference year: the last year before both the pandemic and any plausible anticipation of the coming abortion landscape change. In this framework, any witnessed impacts in 2020 and 2021 are interpreted as pandemic-related rather than being included in the baseline *Dobbs* effect. Furthermore, in our primary specification, we run our analysis separately for public and private (not-for-profit) institutions.

The public-versus-private split is motivated by three key differences between the sectors. First, private institutions tend to draw a larger share of their student body from out-of-state than their public school counterparts.¹ This difference can perhaps be due in part to the second major difference between these institution types: namely, public institutions have lower tuition rates for in-state students (due to state-level subsidies) than out-of-state students whereas private institutions largely do not price-discriminate on residency. The third major difference between these institution types is that of religious affiliation.² Given the correlation between religious affiliation and attitudes on abortion (Woodrum and Davison, 1992; Adamczyk et al., 2021), we take this as yet another reason to examine the two institution groups separately.

Our findings can be stated compactly. On the margins where Walker et al. (2023) and Kane (2025) identify effects (applications, and the gender composition of applications) we estimate consistent nulls at both public and private institutions in our broader sample. In fact, we do not estimate impacts to admissions either. These conclusions challenge the external validity of the application-margin estimates in previous work beyond the slice of elite, selective, out-of-state-intensive institutions those papers examine. Where we do find effects, they run in an interesting direction. It appears that first-time full-time enrollment rose at ban-state institutions relative to never-ban controls, across both genders and in both sectors. Furthermore, primarily at public institutions, acceptance rates across genders appear to fall as retention rates rise for these ban-state schools.

At a minimum, our findings give institutional administrators and state legislators an empirical basis for

¹In 2018, 43% of the incoming student body at private institutions in our sample were out-of-state students, while only 17% of the incoming student body at public institutions in our sample were out-of-state students.

²63% of private institutions in our sample are religiously affiliated. Conversely, there are no religiously affiliated public institutions in our sample.

the claim that state-level abortion policy shapes demand for higher education in their state. That the effects we find at these ban state institutions run *toward* rather than *away* from ban states is, in the context of the wider conversation about the consequences of abortion access, counterintuitive.

The remainder of the paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 details the policy environment, illustrates the importance of abortion access to college hopefuls, highlights related literature. Section 3 presents a simple conceptual framework, mentions a few channels by which *Dobbs* could affect the amenity value of institutions, and then discusses heterogeneity predictions. Section 4 describes the IPEDS panel, the treatment coding, and the sample restrictions. Section 5 presents the event-study design. Section 6 shows the main estimates, organized by outcome type. Section 7 reports robustness and mechanism results. Section 8 concludes.

2 Background and Related Literature

2.1 The *Dobbs* Decision and the Post-2022 Policy Landscape

For nearly fifty years after *Roe v. Wade* (1973), the federal constitution was understood to protect a pregnant woman’s right to choose abortion before fetal viability. *Planned Parenthood v. Casey* (1992) reaffirmed that core right while letting states impose restrictions short of an “undue burden.” State policy under this regime varied widely in intensity, manifesting through parental-notification statutes, waiting periods, TRAP laws, and gestational-age limits at or near viability.

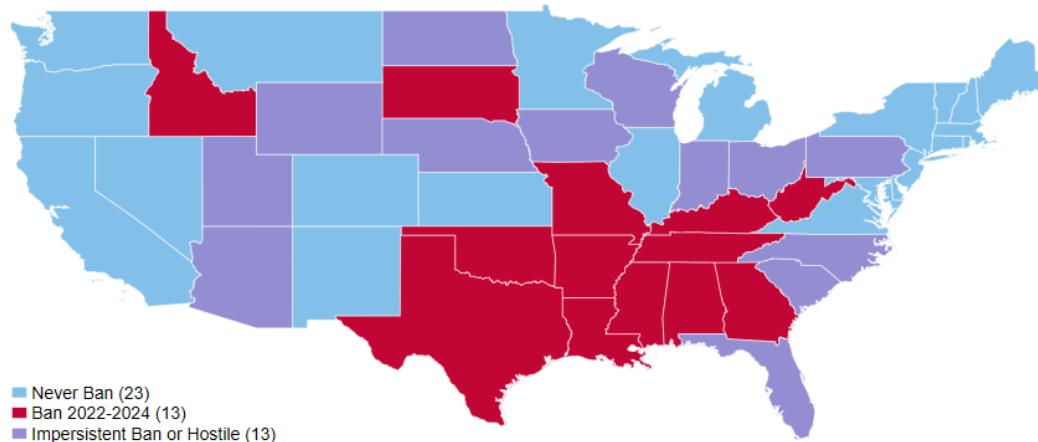
Dobbs v. Jackson Women’s Health Organization dismantled that regime. The case arose from a 2018 Mississippi statute banning most abortions after fifteen weeks of gestation, a restriction that could not survive the “undue burden” framework of the *Casey* decision. The Supreme Court granted certiorari (i.e. agreed to review the lower court’s ruling) in May 2021 and heard oral arguments on December 1, 2021. A draft majority opinion overturning *Roe* leaked to the press in May 2022, and the final decision came down on June 24 of that year. The Court held that the Constitution confers no right to abortion and returned the question to the states.

The state-level response was immediate. Within six months, thirteen states had enacted and begun enforcing total bans or six-week gestational-age bans that would persist for at least the next two years.³ This group is a natural choice for “treated” states whose abortion access was significantly diminished in a persistent manner. A second group of states adopted restrictions that were either short-lived, blocked by courts, enacted in later years, or limited in scope. For instance, Florida enforced a fifteen-week ban from March 2022 until April 2023, with a six-week gestational age abortion ban signed into law by Governor Ron DeSantis thereafter. These intermediate states (“hostile,” in the language of the Center for Reproductive Rights) sit awkwardly in any treated-versus-untreated comparison, and we decide to drop them from estimation for that reason. The full coding description is in Section C.

Despite June 2022 marking the Supreme Court’s decision, the information environment had shifted well before this. The agreement to review the lower court’s ruling, the December 2021 oral arguments, and the

³We treat six-week gestational-age bans as equivalent in practical effect to total bans throughout the analysis: pregnant women may not be aware of their pregnancy before six weeks of gestation and, even if they are, they would have a short window of time to plan/receive the abortion they desire.

Figure 1: US Map of Abortion Policy, 2022-2024



Notes: This figure of the contiguous United States separates states (District of Columbia included) into three policy buckets: Never Ban, Ban 2022-2024, and Impersistent Ban or “Hostile.” The primary specification will compare outcomes at institutions in Never Ban states to those in institutions in Ban 2022-2024 states. This allows for a clean separation of treatment and control states and avoids issues in using those states with impersistent bans as either treated or control states.

May 2022 leak each provided hints that *Roe* was unlikely to survive. To illustrate this, in October 2021, the Guttmacher Institute published a list of twenty-six states it judged “certain or likely” to ban abortion in the event *Roe* fell (Nash and Cross, 2021). Of this list, twenty-five would enact persistent-bans or be labeled as “hostile” to abortion access by December of 2022 (Center for Reproductive Rights, 2022). Thus, reasonably informed citizens had sufficient information to know not only about the importance of the Supreme Court’s ruling for the federal protection of abortion, but which states would be most affected should *Roe* be overturned.

2.2 The Importance of Abortion Access in Education Decisions

For state abortion policy to shape institutional demand, prospective students need to weigh it. Survey evidence from the period around *Dobbs* indicates they do, and that they weigh it for at least two distinct reasons.

The 2024 Lumina–Gallup *State of Higher Education Study* surveyed 14,032 current and prospective college students aged 18–59⁴ about the importance of state reproductive health care policies in their enrollment decisions (Gallup and Lumina Foundation, 2024). Among the currently enrolled, 40% rated these policies extremely or very important; the share among never-enrolled respondents was 33%, and among stopped-out respondents, 29%. Across the three groups, 71% rated state reproductive-healthcare policies as at least somewhat important to their enrollment decisions, up from 67% in late 2022; the share calling these policies highly important rose from 30% to 38% over the same window (Marken and Hrynowski, 2024).

Two further results from the same survey are useful. Among respondents for whom reproductive-healthcare policy is at least somewhat important, 80% would prefer to attend college in a state with greater access; 20% would prefer a state with more restricted access. Separately, 25% of currently enrolled respondents rated “similar political views among other students” as extremely or very important. The two

⁴6,015 currently enrolled, 5,012 stopped-out, and 3,005 never-enrolled.

facts point in different directions and that is the point. A subset of students appears to read state abortion policy as a feature of the local health-care environment, where the ban is a cost. Another subset appears to read the same policy as a signal about who their peers will be, where the ban is an attractor for those who agree with it. The 80/20 split suggests the former set of students would dominate, but the latter is non-trivial. However, which group dominates the witnessed *Dobbs* effect is an empirical question and will depend on the composition of its applicant pool.

Although students report that reproductive healthcare policy is an important determinant in their college decision-making, it's important to contextualize this by evaluating what students rank above abortion access. The same survey reports that 68% of all respondents rated job opportunities in their field of study as extremely or very important, 66% rated cost (tuition, room, and board), 59% rated control over class scheduling, and 49% rated academic reputation. Thus, as researchers might expect, state reproductive-healthcare policy sits below the traditional drivers of college choice.

Survey evidence outside the college-choice literature reinforces that abortion attitudes are widely held among women in the age range relevant to our setting. The 2024 KFF Women's Health Survey of 3,901 women aged 18–49 reports that 74% support legal abortion in all or most cases, 69% support a nationwide right to abortion, and 73% oppose leaving abortion policy to the states. Furthermore, 63% express concern that they or someone close to them would be unable to obtain a pregnancy-preserving abortion if needed ([Kaiser Family Foundation, 2024](#)). The KFF sample is broader than the college-applicant population in one specific way: it includes women older than typical college applicants, but who could be the mothers of current applicants, whose role in college-choice decisions is well-documented ([Grodsky and Jones, 2007](#); [Myers and Myers, 2012](#); [McElrath, 2020](#)) and whom we would expect to weigh state policy environments alongside their children. Furthermore, a poll fielded the same year by Lake Research Partners for the Feminist Majority Foundation, surveying 1,021 young women voters aged 18–39 in nine battleground states, reports more directly that 53% said abortion policy had affected their future plans, 44% had considered or were making plans to relocate to a state with greater abortion access, and 10% reported turning down a job in a state with an abortion ban ([Lake Research Partners and Feminist Majority Foundation, 2022](#)). Stated relocation is not the same as realized relocation, but a stated willingness to relocate at this rate is hard to reconcile with the view that abortion policy is irrelevant to location choice.⁵

Taken together, the survey landscape supports a particular claim: state abortion policy is salient to a meaningful share of the college-applicant population, the salience is rising rather than fading, and stated preferences are split in a meaningful way. Despite the obvious shortcomings of relying on survey data about attitudes to predict behavior, we take these data as evidence that abortion access is important for young college-age individuals, especially women.

⁵A contemporaneous survey of 654 U.S. adolescents aged 14–24 fielded by [Allison et al. \(2023\)](#) in May 2022 finds that 85% were aware of impending changes to abortion access and only 1% reported incorrect information about the “legal landscape”; 42% expressed negative emotions about the changes and another 26% expressed general disagreement. We cite this cautiously given the small sample.

2.3 Related Literature

Our research contributes to two broad strands of literature, namely, the economics of abortion access and the determinants of school choice. Although we distinguish ourselves importantly in both the empirical objects of interest and empirical strategy, we discuss these strands briefly here and then describe the research that most closely resembles our own.

The economics of abortion access has largely treated changes in abortion access as changes in the cost of avoiding an unintended birth. Research extending for at least 50 years ([Deyak and Smith, 1976](#)) has questioned how changing access has affected outcomes such as fertility ([Levine et al., 1996](#); [Kane and Staiger, 1996](#); [Levine et al., 1999](#); [Fischer et al., 2018](#); [Lindo et al., 2020](#); [Jones and Pineda-Torres, 2024](#)), education ([Goldin and Katz, 2002](#); [Myers, 2017](#); [Ralph et al., 2019](#); [Jones and Pineda-Torres, 2024](#)), crime ([Donohue and Levitt, 2001](#); [Joyce, 2004, 2009](#); [Kendall and Tamura, 2010](#); [Donohue and Levitt, 2020](#)), and even the composition of birth cohorts ([Gruber et al., 1999](#); [Ananat et al., 2009](#)).

Although the previously mentioned papers analyzed either the expansion of abortion access via *Roe v. Wade* or the encroachment of abortion restrictions after *Planned Parenthood v. Casey*, some recent work has studied the various impacts of the elimination of abortion access resultant from the *Dobbs* decision. [Dench et al. \(2024, 2025\)](#) highlight fertility impacts, [Dave et al. \(2025\)](#) study intimate partner violence, and [Adrjan et al. \(2026\)](#) investigate worker responses to firms' stances on abortion.

As stated, these papers treat abortion access changes as a change in the cost of avoiding an unintended birth, while we treat abortion access as a location-specific amenity. Although this is not the common framework, we are preceded by some recent work that we interpret as more closely aligned with our framework. [Dench et al. \(2025\)](#) use a synthetic difference-in-differences design to evaluate the impact of the *Dobbs* decision and the abortion access variation that followed on population flows, finding that bans increase net migration outflows. [Dench et al. \(2026\)](#) test whether U.S. housing markets priced in the value of abortion access, estimating that "total abortion bans reduced rents by an average of 2.2 percent from July 2022 through June 2025." Whether examining the legalization, restriction, or outright prohibition of abortion, the evidence suggests that reproductive policy affects not only reproductive outcomes, but also a wide range of downstream social, economic, and demographic outcomes.

Given our outcome of interest (changes in demand for education at particular institutions), we find helpful antecedents in the economics of school choice literature as well. The school-choice literature in economics has, for the better part of forty years, treated college attendance as a discrete choice over a menu of institutions whose attributes the student weighs against price. [Fuller et al. \(1982\)](#) use a conditional-logit model in which tuition, distance, and individual characteristics jointly determine which institution a student selects. [Long \(2004a\)](#) updates that framework across three (classes of '72, '82, and '92) cohorts and shows that the weights students place on cost, quality, and proximity have shifted over time, with cost mattering less for the average student than it did in the 1970s and quality mattering more. [Epple et al. \(2003\)](#) embed a similar choice problem inside an equilibrium sorting model in which colleges seek to maximize the quality of educational experience provided to their students. More recently, [Fillmore \(2023\)](#) studies the ways colleges price-discriminate on Free Application for Federal Student Aid (FAFSA) information and what restricting that information would do to the college market.

The subset of the literature that maps most closely onto our design works in reduced form. Rather than recover preference parameters, these papers exploit a sharp policy shock that shifts one element of the institutional bundle and trace how applications and enrollment respond. [Long \(2004b\)](#) studies the abolition of affirmative action in California and Texas and finds that application portfolios shifted in ways that revealed students’ beliefs about admission probability. [Hinrichs \(2012\)](#) extends the question to a wider set of state bans and documents that “for the typical student and the typical college, affirmative action bans have no effect. However, affirmative action bans decrease underrepresented minority enrollment at selective colleges”. [Bleemer \(2022\)](#) links Proposition 209 (which banned race-based affirmative action at California public universities in 1998) to wages using administrative records and shows that the policy reshaped not only where students enrolled but where they ended up in the labor market. [Knight and Schiff \(2022\)](#) exploits institutions’ adoption of the Common Application and shows that lowering an administrative friction increased applications received by schools, increased out-of-state enrollment, changed the composition of students.

The point at which these two literatures meet remains thin. We are aware of three papers that study whether post-*Dobbs* abortion restrictions changed demand for higher-education institutions. [Walker et al. \(2023\)](#) examine the female share of undergraduate applications at 71 universities drawn from the top 100 in the *U.S. News* national-university rankings over 2018–2022. They estimate a nearly one-percentage-point decline in the female share of freshman applicants at institutions in ban states, with the effect concentrated among top-50 institutions and schools drawing heavily from out of state. Their evidence therefore speaks most directly to selective universities whose applicants have unusually broad choice sets. [Hess \(2024\)](#) studies a different market: applications to 154 medical schools across 46 states. In contrast to the undergraduate evidence, he finds that abortion restrictions increased the female share of medical-school applications by 0.65 percentage points in 2022 and 1.17 percentage points in 2023, with no detectable change in the out-of-state share. He interprets the positive effect as plausibly related to applicants’ specialty interests, especially obstetrics and gynecology. [Kane \(2025\)](#) uses restricted Common App data to study high-achieving⁶ applicants, comparing women to men before and after *Dobbs*. She estimates that abortion bans reduced the probability that a high-achieving woman applied to a school in a total-ban state by 2.7 percentage points, with larger responses among applicants from states without abortion restrictions and from more liberal counties.

Our contribution is to move this question from a narrow application-margin setting to a larger institutional-demand setting. Prior work has shown that abortion bans affected where some students applied, especially among highly selective universities and high-achieving applicants. We study a larger and less restricted sample: 894 four-year public and private not-for-profit institutions across 36 states. That scope allows us to ask whether the application effects found in earlier work extend to the wider higher-education market, rather than just for the students and institutions with unusually wide choice sets. We also estimate the response separately for public and private institutions. This split matters because the two sectors face different applicant pools, pricing rules, residency incentives, and religious-affiliation patterns, all of which may change the way a state abortion ban enters the college-choice problem. Finally, our 2010–2024 panel allows us to separate post-*Dobbs* movements from the earlier COVID-related disruptions. For outcomes whose treated-control differences begin in 2020 or 2021, we interpret the estimates cautiously, for outcomes that move only after

⁶This is based on the cut score for the 90th percentile of SAT/ACT test-takers in her sample in 2016.

2022, the timing is more consistent with a *Dobbs* response.

3 Conceptual Framework

This section sketches the decision problem faced by a prospective student in light of the shock that the *Dobbs* decision imposed. We do not estimate the parameters of the model that follows; its role is to discipline the sign and heterogeneity predictions that motivate the empirical design in Section 5.

3.1 Institutional Choice as an Attribute Bundle

Consider a prospective student i (in practice, a student and their parents) who selects institution j from a feasible set $\mathcal{J}_i$ to maximize

$$U_{ij} = f(q_j, p_{ij}, A_j, \pi_{s(j)}, \varepsilon_{ij}), \quad (1)$$

where q_j represents academic quality, p_{ij} is the price i faces at j (which may depend on residency), A_j is a vector of institution-specific amenities (location, peer composition, campus life), $\pi_{s(j)}$ is the policy environment of the state $s(j)$ in which institution j is located, and ε_{ij} is an idiosyncratic taste shock. Observed demand at the institutional level (applications, admissions yield, enrollment) aggregates individual choices $\arg \max_{j \in \mathcal{J}_i} U_{ij}$ over the applicant pool relevant to each institution.

This attribute-bundle framing is standard in the college-choice literature, which has largely used discrete-choice models to recover structural preferences over institutional characteristics. Our empirical object is distinct: rather than identifying preference parameters from revealed choices, we exploit a plausibly exogenous change in π_s (the *Dobbs v. Jackson Women's Health Organization* decision and the state-level ban regimes that followed) to estimate reduced-form demand responses using a difference-in-differences design.

3.2 Channels Through Which *Dobbs v. Jackson Women's Health Organization* Perturbs Demand

The *Dobbs* shock changes one element of π_s : the availability of legal abortion. In this section, we present a non-exhaustive list of two potential channels, neither mutually exclusive, which translate the *Dobbs* shock change into shifts in institutional demand.

Health-care amenity. Access to abortion is part of the bundle of reproductive health care available to students while enrolled. It has option value ex ante (although most women will not seek an abortion during college,⁷ the option to do so provides insurance against an uncertain future need) and it is bundled with the broader availability of reproductive health services, which survey evidence indicates students weight non-trivially in college-choice decisions (see the Lumina–Gallup and KFF evidence discussed in Section 2). A state-level ban lowers the amenity value of institutions in that state for students who assign positive weight to this attribute, shifting demand downward.

⁷See Jones and Jerman (2017) for lifetime abortion incidence calculations.

Political identity. Furthermore, a non-trivial share of students find it important that, at the school they’re considering, the political views of students are similar to their own (see the Lumina–Gallup survey evidence discussed in Section 2). For students who oppose abortion restrictions, a ban reduces the identity-amenity value of ban-state institutions, strengthening the health-care channel. For students who support such restrictions, the same policy raises the identity-amenity value of ban-state institutions. Although survey evidence suggests the first group is numerically larger among college-age populations, because the two groups sort differently across the applicant pools of public and private institutions and across regions, the direction of the net political-identity effect at any given institution is not determined beforehand.

Aggregation and net sign. The institution-level demand response is the net of these two, and potentially many more, channels. When the health-care channel and the pro-choice component of the political-identity channel dominate, demand in ban states falls. When the pro-life leg of the political-identity channel or peer-composition effects dominate (or when health-care access is a lower-weight amenity for the marginal applicant) demand in ban states can rise. The sign of the net effect is therefore an empirical question. We note but do not formally model additional plausible channels: local (to the school) abortion support (i.e. the voting habits of the surrounding population, especially as it differs from the state as a whole), expectations over post-graduation labor markets, etc.

3.3 Heterogeneity Predictions

The framework generates three predictions that guide the empirical work.

Public versus private. Private four-year institutions draw a substantially larger share of first-time students from out of state than do public institutions.⁸ A larger out-of-state share plausibly suggests the applicant pool selects over a wider set of state policy environments, raising the elasticity of demand to any single state’s policy. Furthermore, the student body at private institutions in future ban states was comprised of a higher share of students originating from states that would not ban abortion in 2022 and thereafter, perhaps implying a more heterogeneous student body in terms of political affiliations.⁹ This disparity is likely due in part to the subsidization of the enrollment of in-state students at public institutions, tipping the scale in favor of local applicants. Given these important differences in the types of students drawn to these institutions, we expect to see differences in the demand response at public and private schools, although the expected difference is unknown *ex ante*.

Gender. The health-care channel of abortion access impacts women directly and men only indirectly, highlighted by the fact that there is an overwhelming focus on whether and how abortion access changes impact childbearing age women. *Ceteris paribus*, our framework suggests women’s demand responses would be at least as large in magnitude as men’s, especially with respect to the health care channel. However, with

⁸In 2018, private institutions’ freshman undergraduate enrollment was 43% out-of-state, compared to only 17% for their public counterparts.

⁹In 2018, at institutions in states that would ban abortion from 2022 onward, the share of freshman from never ban states was 17% at private institutions and 9% at public institutions.

respect to the political identity channel, or general attitudes towards abortion access, gender inconsistently correlates with abortion support (Osborne et al., 2022). Thus, to the extent that there are differences in the impact of and attitudes toward abortion access, we surmise that the *Dobbs* response may be different within these groups, although the expected difference is unknown ex ante for reasons similar to that discussed earlier. For that reason, when possible, we show our regression results across both genders.

3.4 Scope of the Analysis

A limitation of scope is worth making explicit before the empirical section. First, the institutional unit of analysis means we identify the net aggregate demand response at each institution, not the preferences of individual students. The framework’s channels are not separately identified from institution-level outcomes alone and the paper’s contribution is to the aggregate response, which is itself a policy-relevant quantity for institutional administrators and state legislators weighing the higher-education consequences of abortion policy.

4 Data

We combine institution-level outcomes from the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS) with state-level abortion policy and county-level demographic and economic covariates. The unit of analysis is the institution-year, and the panel covers the 2010–2011 through 2024–2025 academic years.¹⁰

4.1 Institutional Data: IPEDS, 2010–2024

Institutional outcomes come from the IPEDS Access database files published by the National Center for Education Statistics. We retain baccalaureate-or-higher institutions in SECTOR 1 (public, four-year or above) and SECTOR 2 (private not-for-profit, four-year or above). Private for-profit four-year institutions (SECTOR 3) are excluded for reasons such as underreporting of important variables (application and admission counts) and student composition and business model differences.

The outcome variables fall into six categories. *Applications and admissions* comprise counts by sex, along with the acceptance rate, defined as admissions divided by applications. *Enrollment* comprises counts of full-time, first-time, degree-seeking undergraduates by sex and the conversion rate defined as first-time full-time enrollees divided by admits. *Composition* measures include the female-to-male ratio among first-time, full-time enrollees and the share of first-time, full-time students enrolling from out of state (computed from the residence module, which IPEDS requires only in even years). *Origin decompositions* count first-time enrollees separately from never-ban states, from persistent-ban states, and from hostile states. *Retention* is the first-time, full-time cohort retention rate. *Prices* are in-state and out-of-state published tuition and fees for full-time undergraduates, converted to 2024 dollars using the BLS CPI-U annual average. Count variables and prices are logged in the main specifications while shares and rates enter as levels.

¹⁰We refer to academic years by their fall term throughout; e.g., “2022” denotes the 2022–2023 academic year.

4.2 Treatment Assignment and Geographic Controls

We assign treatment status at the state level based on the presence and persistence of abortion bans following the June 2022 *Dobbs v. Jackson Women’s Health Organization* decision. A state is coded as a persistent-ban (treated) state if it had a total ban or a six-week gestational ban in effect in each of 2022, 2023, and 2024. A state is coded as a never-ban (control) state if it had no such ban in any year from 2022 through 2024 and was not designated “hostile” to abortion access by the Center for Reproductive Rights in December 2022.¹¹ We drop these states from the estimation sample as an identifying-assumption choice: their policy environments are neither a clean treatment nor a clean control, and retaining them would contaminate the comparison. Policy coding was constructed by hand from the Center for Reproductive Rights state-policy tracker (retrieved via the Internet Archive Wayback Machine) and cross-referenced with state-by-state abortion policy outlines. Section C reports the full state-by-state coding.

County-level covariates, lagged by one year in the main specifications, come from five sources. Poverty rates and median household income are from the Census Bureau’s Small Area Income and Poverty Estimates (SAIPE) program. The unemployment rate is from the Bureau of Labor Statistics’ Local Area Unemployment Statistics (LAUS) program. Educational attainment shares for the population aged 25 and over (shares with a high school diploma or GED, an associate’s, a bachelor’s, a master’s, a professional, or a doctoral degree) are from the American Community Survey 5-year estimates, 2010 through 2023. The Democratic vote share is constructed from the MIT Election Data and Science Lab’s county presidential returns file and linearly interpolated between presidential election years. The population of women of childbearing age (15–45) comes from the county-by-month abortion clinic distances panel released by [Myers \(2026\)](#).

Because Connecticut redrew its county-equivalent geographies in 2022, we fix each Connecticut institution’s county FIPS code to its 2021 value throughout the panel to preserve a stable geographic identifier; the county-level covariates merged to these institutions use the 2021 geography.

4.3 Sample Restrictions and Panel Construction

The analysis sample is built through a sequence of restrictions, each reported in Table 1. Starting from all four-year institutions in SECTOR 1 or 2 that appear in every year of IPEDS from 2010 through 2024 (the balanced institution panel), we apply three further restrictions.

First, we drop institutions whose first-time, full-time female-to-male enrollment ratio falls outside the 5th-to-95th-percentile range computed over the pre-treatment, pre-COVID years 2016–2019. The resulting band, approximately 0.09 to 2.57, attempts to exclude men’s and women’s colleges and a small number of other institutions with extreme sex ratios; the restriction requires an institution to remain within this band in every year 2010–2024. Without this winsorization, puzzling features like the application of women to Wabash College (which does not enroll women ever in our sample) would be allowed to remain. Furthermore, the inclusion of colleges with tail-of-the-distribution gender ratios could distort analysis of the impact on gendered enrollment ratios. For instance, Smith College’s female-to-male full-time undergraduate ratio fell

¹¹From their definition : “The “Hostile” category means that these states and territories have expressed a desire to prohibit abortion entirely. These states and territories are extremely vulnerable to the revival of old abortion bans or the enactment of new ones, and none of them has legal protections for abortion.”

from 2570:1 to 1304:1 from 2010 to 2011 due to the addition of one extra male in 2011. We circumvent the issues these outliers could cause by removing them.

Second, we drop institutions located in Alaska, Hawaii, Puerto Rico, and the U.S. Virgin Islands, restricting attention to the contiguous United States and the District of Columbia.

Third, we drop institutions in abortion “hostile” states, retaining only those in persistent-ban and never-ban states. After these restrictions, the estimation sample contains 894 institutions enrolling approximately 5.52 million undergraduates as of 2021 (the year directly prior to the *Dobbs* decision.), broken down as 234 public and 328 private institutions in never-ban states and 155 public and 177 private institutions in persistent-ban states.

Table 1: Sample restriction cascade

Restriction	Institutions	Undergraduates (2021)	% of start
Balanced 2010–2024, SECTOR 1 or 2	1,920	8,645,805	100.0
Drop men’s and women’s colleges	1,287	7,968,990	92.2
Drop AK, HI, PR, VI	1,108	6,740,797	78.0
Drop hostile states	894	5,520,537	63.9

Notes: Starting sample is the set of institutions in SECTOR 1 (public four-year) or SECTOR 2 (private not-for-profit four-year) that report in every year from 2010 through 2024. Men’s and women’s colleges are defined as institutions whose first-time, full-time female-to-male enrollment ratio falls outside the 5th-to-95th-percentile band computed over 2016–2019 in any year 2010–2024.

A fourth, outcome-specific restriction governs each regression. Because IPEDS reporting of individual variables is not uniformly complete even among institutions that report something every year, our baseline sample for each outcome variable y is outcome-by-outcome balanced: for a given regression on y , we retain only institutions within the 894-institution sample that report y in every year 2010 through 2024. Sample sizes therefore vary somewhat across outcomes and the number of contributing institutions is reported in each regression. One exception to the balance requirement concerns the residence-of-freshmen module, which IPEDS requires institutions to complete only in even years; balanced reporting in odd years is particularly sparse. For outcomes built from this survey component (the out-of-state enrollment share and the origin-state decompositions) we use an *even-year balanced* sample, requiring the institution to report the variable in each of the eight even years 2010 through 2024.

Table 2 reports summary statistics for the 894-institution sample, separately for public and private institutions and for control and treated states, over the pre-treatment years of 2010–2021. A few features of the sample are worth noting. First, private institutions draw a larger share of their student body from out-of-state within both treated and control states. County-level covariates differ predictably across treatment and control: median household income is roughly \$16,000–\$20,000 higher in control-state counties, the poverty rate is four percentage points lower, the share of adults with a bachelor’s degree is three to five percentage points higher, and the Democratic vote share is fifteen to eighteen percentage points higher. The main event-study specifications absorb these fixed differences through institution fixed effects; lagged controls are included to absorb time-varying local conditions.

Table 2: Pre-Treatment Summary Statistics by Sector and Treatment Group (2010–2021)

Variable	Public				Private			
	Control		Treated		Control		Treated	
	Mean	(SD)	Mean	(SD)	Mean	(SD)	Mean	(SD)
Total Applications	13,975	(16,248)	7,468	(7,646)	7,101	(10,002)	3,444	(5,924)
Total Admissions	7,898	(7,036)	5,170	(4,818)	3,209	(3,628)	1,700	(2,132)
Acceptance Rate	0.67	(0.20)	0.73	(0.17)	0.61	(0.23)	0.64	(0.20)
First-Time FT Enroll Rate	0.30	(0.19)	0.39	(0.13)	0.27	(0.15)	0.34	(0.17)
Full-Time Undergraduates	9,017	(7,890)	7,898	(7,507)	2,783	(3,166)	1,765	(2,106)
Female-Male Applicant Ratio	1.27	(0.36)	1.44	(0.37)	1.33	(0.44)	1.37	(0.44)
Female-Male Undergrad Ratio	1.22	(0.38)	1.37	(0.35)	1.26	(0.41)	1.27	(0.39)
White Enrollment Share	0.54	(0.22)	0.57	(0.24)	0.58	(0.17)	0.60	(0.23)
Black Enrollment Share	0.10	(0.14)	0.19	(0.23)	0.08	(0.08)	0.17	(0.22)
Out-of-State Enrollment Share	0.15	(0.19)	0.18	(0.17)	0.46	(0.27)	0.37	(0.24)
Out-of-State Tuition (2024 \$)	\$26,746	(\$10,789)	\$21,679	(\$7,484)	\$46,679	(\$13,500)	\$31,152	(\$12,561)
Typical Room Charge	\$6,424	(\$2,324)	\$4,777	(\$1,478)	\$6,704	(\$2,178)	\$4,724	(\$1,752)
Typical Board Charge	\$4,227	(\$1,487)	\$3,472	(\$702)	\$4,993	(\$1,179)	\$4,194	(\$1,018)
Full Professor Salary (2024 \$)	\$135,288	(\$32,560)	\$113,274	(\$27,187)	\$130,069	(\$49,033)	\$93,315	(\$34,929)
<i>County Characteristics</i>								
Median HH Income (2024 \$)	\$78,697	(\$20,544)	\$62,118	(\$12,536)	\$84,395	(\$20,527)	\$64,046	(\$13,105)
Unemployment Rate	6.38	(2.55)	5.89	(2.30)	6.16	(2.46)	5.99	(2.40)
Share in Poverty	0.15	(0.05)	0.19	(0.06)	0.13	(0.05)	0.17	(0.05)
Share 25+ with Bachelor's	0.20	(0.06)	0.17	(0.05)	0.21	(0.05)	0.16	(0.05)
Democrat Vote Share	0.56	(0.14)	0.41	(0.15)	0.58	(0.15)	0.40	(0.17)
Institutions (2010–2024 balanced)	234		155		328		177	

5 Empirical Strategy

Our estimating equation is a two-way fixed-effects event study in which institutions in persistent-ban states are the treated group and institutions in never-ban states are the controls. For an outcome Y_{ist} observed for institution i located in state s in year t , we estimate

$$Y_{ist} = \alpha_i + \gamma_t + \sum_{\substack{k=2010 \\ k \neq 2019}}^{2024} \beta_k \mathbf{1}\{t=k\} \cdot \text{Ban}_{s(i)} + X'_{s(i),t-1} \theta + \varepsilon_{ist}, \quad (2)$$

where $\text{Ban}_{s(i)} = 1$ if institution i 's state had a total or six-week gestational ban in effect in each of 2022, 2023, and 2024, and zero for institutions in never-ban states. The fixed effects α_i absorb all time-invariant institutional characteristics (including fixed differences in selectivity, religious affiliation, and unchanging local characteristics) and the year fixed effects γ_t absorb shocks common to all four-year institutions in a given year. The vector $X_{s(i),t-1}$ contains one-year-lagged county-level covariates: the poverty rate, median household income, the linearly interpolated Democratic presidential vote share, five educational-attainment shares of the population aged twenty-five and over, the population of women of childbearing age, and the unemployment rate. Standard errors are clustered at the state level, the level at which treatment is assigned. Our primary specification is estimated separately for public and private not-for-profit institutions for reasons discussed earlier on.

The coefficients of interest $\{\beta_k\}$ trace the time path of the outcome in institutions within treated states relative to those in control states, each normalized to the 2019 baseline. The choice of 2019 as the reference year reflects two constraints that cannot be satisfied simultaneously by any other year in the panel. First, 2019 is the last year before both the COVID-19 disruption and any plausible information shock from *Dobbs*. A reference year after 2019 would therefore bundle some combination of pandemic and anticipation effects into the baseline effect. Second, because every β_k is read relative to 2019, the 2020 and 2021 coefficients are interpreted as pandemic coefficients and help assess whether the estimated 2022–2024 effects represent a *Dobbs* effect or an indistinguishable persistence of the heterogeneous Covid response in to-be-ban states.

The identifying assumption is the standard parallel-trends condition: absent the abortion bans, the outcomes of institutions in persistent-ban and never-ban states would have evolved in parallel from 2019 forward. The pre-period coefficients $\{\beta_{2011}, \dots, \beta_{2018}\}$ provide a visual test of this assumption, and we interpret as credible any specification in which these coefficients are statistically indistinguishable from zero.

Each regression is estimated on an outcome-by-outcome balanced panel: for outcome y , we restrict attention to institutions in the 894-institution sample of Table 1 that report y in every year from 2010 through 2024. Furthermore, outcomes constructed from the IPEDS residence-of-freshmen module (the out-of-state share and the origin-state enrollment decompositions) are instead estimated on an even-year-balanced subsample, with 2018 as the reference year, because IPEDS requires reporting of this survey component only in even years.

Count outcomes are logged in the main specifications: log applications and admissions (by sex), log first-time full-time and total full-time undergraduate enrollment (by sex), log enrollment counts by origin-state group, and logs of real in-state and out-of-state tuition, room, and board. Logging count outcomes produces coefficients interpretable as approximate proportional changes, which aids in interpreting effects across a wide array of institution sizes. Conversely, rates, shares, and ratios such as the acceptance rate, the conversion rate, the female-to-male enrollment ratio, the out-of-state enrollment share, and the retention rate enter in as levels.

6 Results

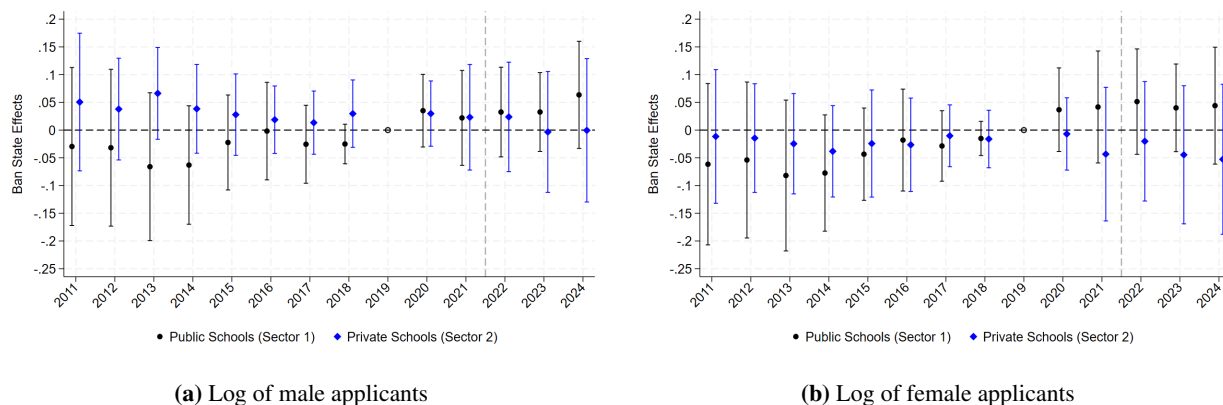
6.1 Applications and Admissions

In summary, we find no evidence of an impact to applications or admissions across genders. We estimate consistent nulls for the log of applicants for men and women in both sectors, with pre-treatment coefficients that seem to corroborate the parallel trends assumption (Figure 2). These results suggest there is no statistically significant proportional impact to the aggregated application outcomes in ban-state institutions. We follow this with test for impacts on the female share of applications in Figure 3. Unlike [Walker et al. \(2023\)](#), for which the set of institutions was elite schools boasting high selectivity, we find no evidence of a statistically significant impact to this metric for public or private schools.

Admissions counts behave similarly: log of admissions counts for men and women yield no detectable response in public or private institutions (Figure 4). Interestingly, as seen in (Figure 5) and (Figure 6), we do find evidence that the acceptance rate *fell* for public institutions when looking at all students, males, and

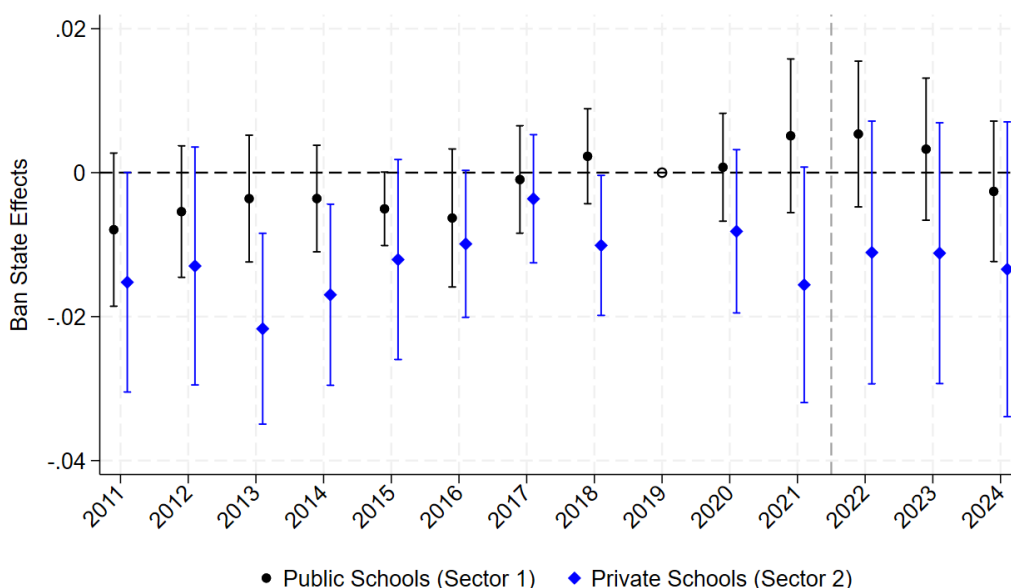
females. This would imply that institutions in ban states were becoming relatively more selective. However, given that there seems to be a treatment effect for to-be-ban states beginning in 2021 (prior to the *Dobbs* decision and any likely anticipation of the impact), we cannot separate the estimated effects from what could be persistent Covid-related effects that impacted schools which would also be located in future abortion ban states.

Figure 2: Event-study estimates: log applicant counts by sex



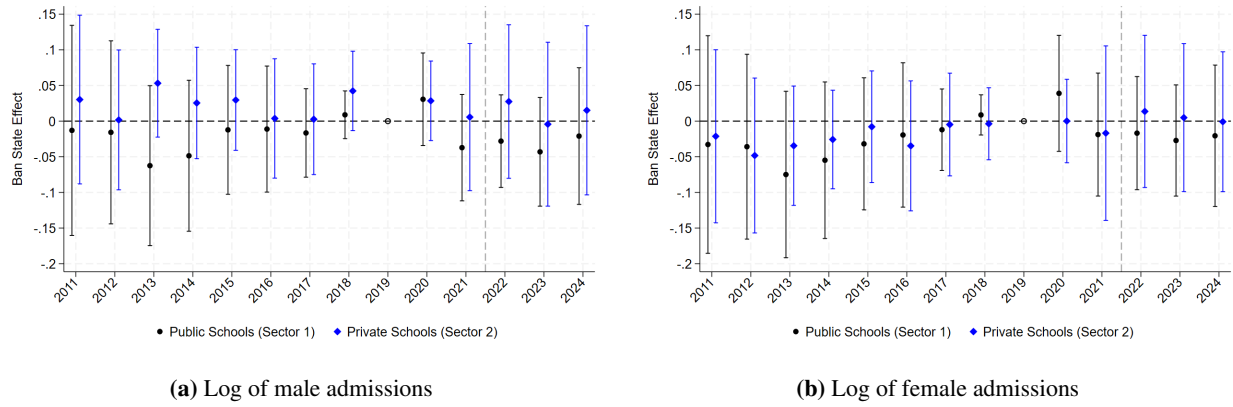
Notes: Coefficients are estimated from Equation (2) with 2019 as the reference year, separately for public (SECTOR 1) and private not-for-profit (SECTOR 2) institutions. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. The vertical line at 2021.5 marks the time between the Fall 2021 and Fall 2022 outcomes, representing the *Dobbs* decision shock. The balanced reporting requirement leaves 332 public and 444 private institutions in the male and female applicant regressions.

Figure 3: Event-study estimates: female share of applications



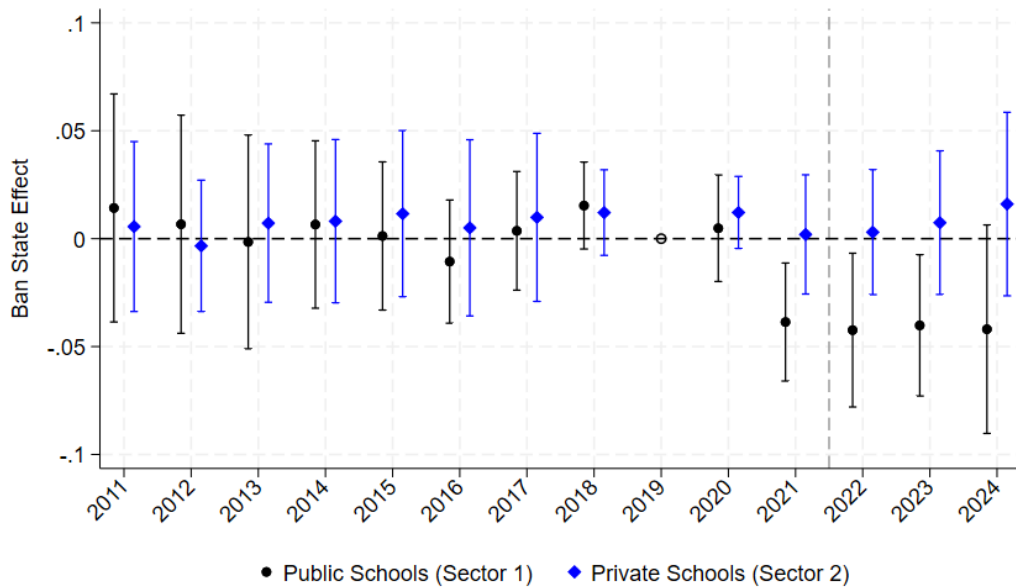
Notes: The dependent variable is female applications divided by total applications. Specification as in Figure 2. The balanced reporting requirement leaves 332 public and 444 private institutions in the female share-of-applications regressions.

Figure 4: Event-study estimates: log admissions counts by sex



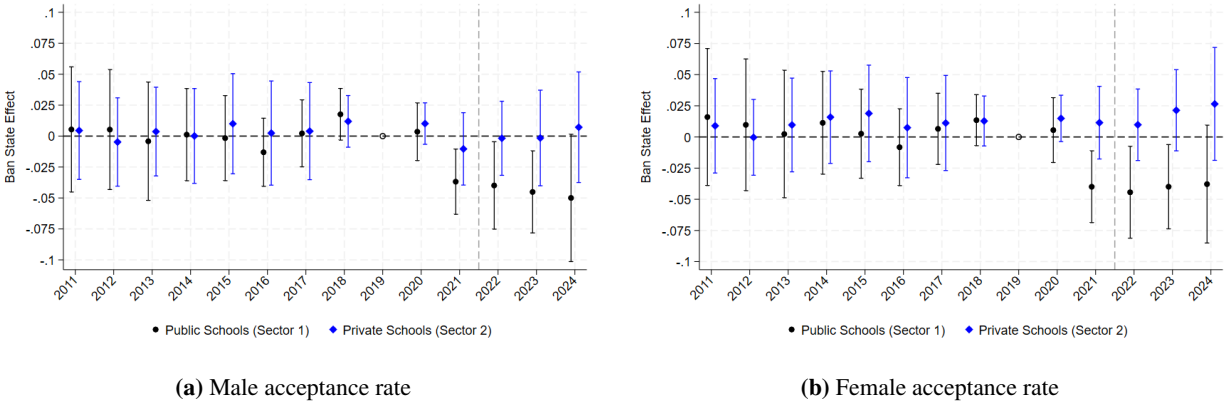
Notes: Specification as in Figure 2. The balanced reporting requirement leaves 332 public and 444 private institutions in the male and female admissions regressions.

Figure 5: Event-study estimates: acceptance rate



Notes: The dependent variable is the acceptance rate, total admissions divided by total applications. Specification as in Figure 2. The balanced reporting requirement leaves 332 public and 444 private institutions in the acceptance rate regressions.

Figure 6: Event-study estimates: acceptance rate by sex

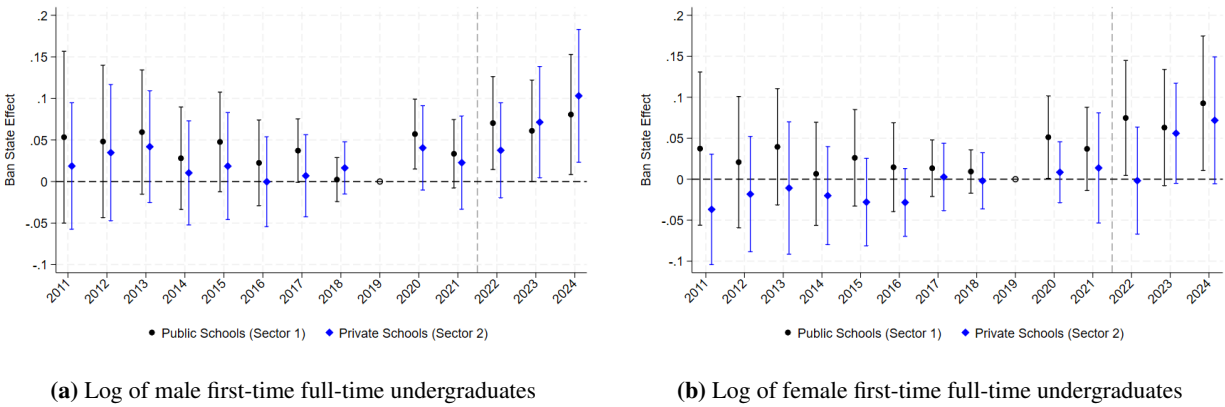


Notes: Specification as in Figure 2. The balanced reporting requirement leaves 332 public and 444 private institutions in the male and female acceptance rate regressions.

6.2 Enrollment

Despite a lack of evidence that students' application behavior or schools' admission behavior (besides an early impact to the acceptance rate) changed in response to abortion bans, we do find evidence of freshman, first-time, full-time enrollment effects. Namely, Figure 7 seems to suggest that enrollment (if anything) rose across genders and across institutions for both sectors. Despite the estimated positive impact at public schools in 2020, it does appear that this enrollment boost is concentrated in the post-*Dobbs* years, indicating that the enrollment effects are believably interpreted as abortion access, and not Covid-response related. Specifically, we estimate a 6-8 percent relative increase in male freshman, first-time, full-time enrollment at public schools and 3-10 percent increase at private schools. For females, we estimate a 7-9 percent and 0-7 percent relative increase for public and private schools (respectively). To help with interpreting these figures, the following are the mean freshman enrollment counts for ban state schools across sectors in 2022: 791 (Male, Public), 183 (Male, Private), 1050 (Female, Public), 228 (Female, Private).

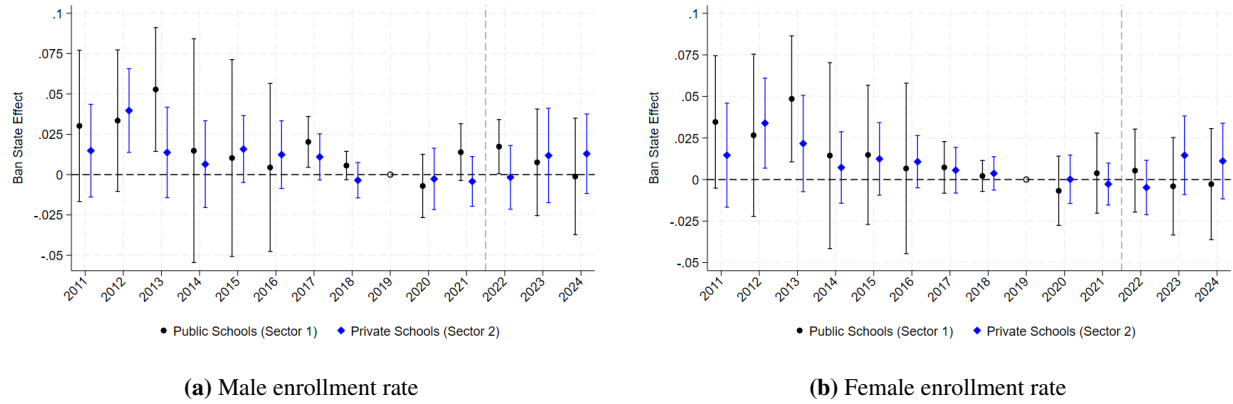
Figure 7: Event-study estimates: log first-time, full-time, degree-seeking enrollment by sex



Notes: Specification as in Figure 2. The balanced reporting requirement leaves 389 public and 505 private institutions in the male and female first-time, full-time enrollment regressions.

In contrast to the previous findings, when analyzing the enrollment rates, defined as the count of actual enrollments divided by the count of admissions, we do not find any evidence that the abortion bans impacted the ability of institutions to convert admitted students into enrolling students. Figure 8 suggests that there were not statistically significant differences (outside of a positive for men at public schools in 2022) in the enrollment rate across genders and for either public or private schools in the post-*Dobbs* era. Interpreted thusly, this would suggest that schools in ban states saw no relative change to their ability to convert admits to enrollees.

Figure 8: Event-study estimates: first-time, full-time enrollment rate by sex



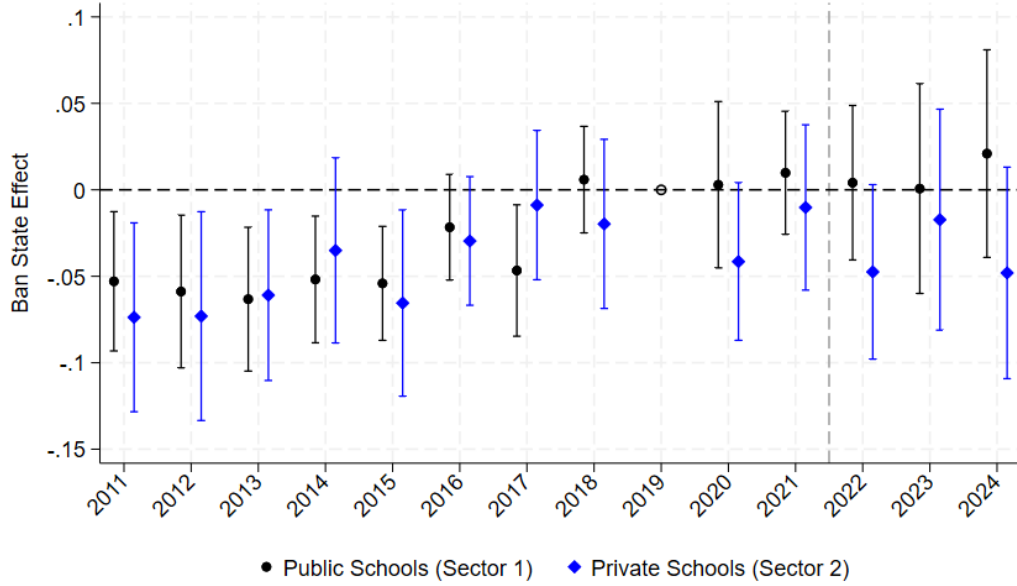
Notes: The dependent variable is the freshman first-time, full-time enrollment rate, defined as first-time full-time enrollments divided by the number of admissions. Specification as in Figure 2. The balanced reporting requirement leaves 332 public and 444 private institutions in the male and female enrollment rate regressions.

Another outcome of interest is the gender composition at these impacted schools: are there detectable changes in the gender ratio of the incoming classes of students? Figure 9 would appear to imply that abortion bans in the affected institutions did not have a statistically significant impact on the ratio of female to male first-time, full-time undergraduates. Furthermore, even if there were statistically significant differences detected in our post-treatment years, we could not interpret it as a “treatment effect” as easily given the statistically significant differences in the ban and non-ban group prior to 2019.

The tests thus far have looked at the newest batches of students in every year, but perhaps we should investigate potential effects for all students. Figure 10 plots the estimated proportional impact of abortion bans on the total number of male and female full-time undergraduate enrollment. As with freshman enrollment, it appears that, if anything, enrollment was rising at the institutions experiencing abortion access restrictions. Although the impact appears to be concentrated at public schools, these schools suggest 5-7.6% increases in male enrollment and 4.8-8.2% increases in female enrollment. Furthermore, we interpret these effects as being *Dobbs*-related given the lack of a statistically significant effect between the treated and control group in 2020 and 2021. To help with interpreting these figures, the following are the mean total full-time undergraduate enrollment counts for ban state schools across sectors in 2022: 3295 (Male, Public), 727 (Male, Private), 4295 (Female, Public), 945 (Female, Private).

For undergraduate enrollment, it would also appear to be the case that the ratio of gendered enrollment is not affected as illustrated by Figure 11. However, the gender ratio of total enrollment experiences the same

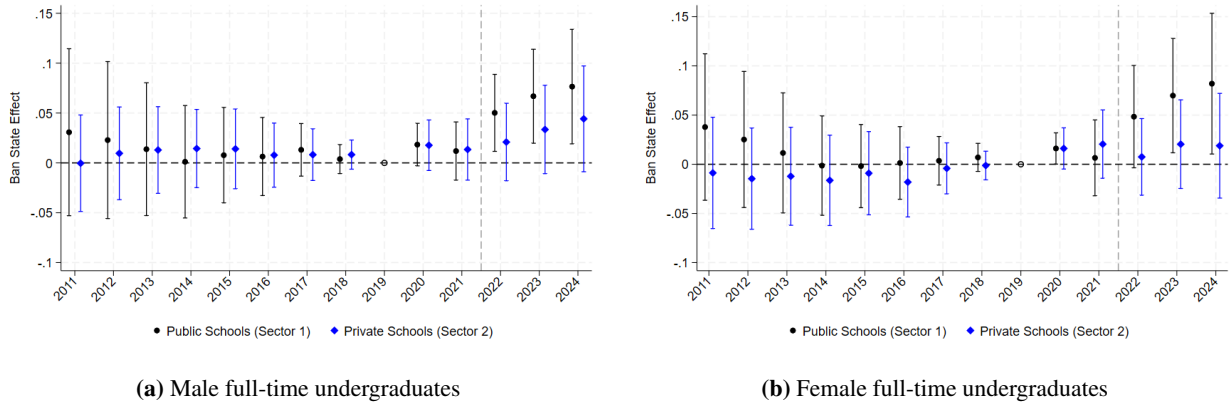
Figure 9: Event-study estimates: female-to-male ratio of first-time, full-time enrollment



Notes: Specification as in Figure 2. The balanced reporting requirement leaves 389 public and 505 private institutions in the female-to-male first-time, full-time undergraduate ratio regressions.

pre-treatment trends violation as seen in the gender ratio of freshman enrollment.

Figure 10: Event-study estimates: log total full-time, degree-seeking undergraduate enrollment by sex



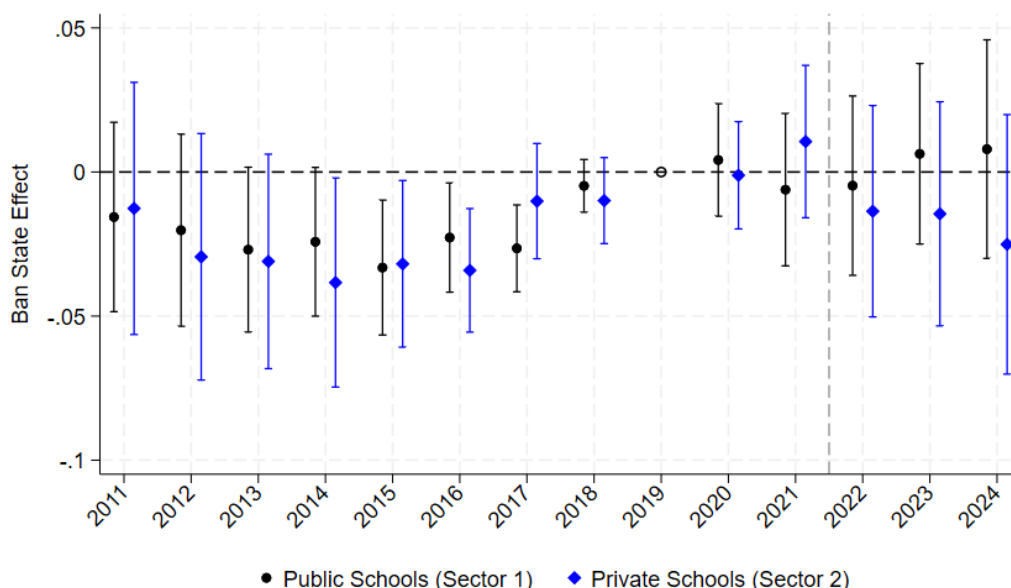
Notes: Specification as in Figure 2. The balanced reporting requirement leaves 389 public and 505 private institutions in the male and female total full-time, degree-seeking undergraduate enrollment regressions.

6.3 Student Origin

We move now to investigating the impacts of changing abortion access on student origin. Specifically, using the even-year reporting of the residence of first-time, full-time students,¹² we test whether there are differential impacts to the share of students coming from out-of-state and proportional impacts to the number

¹²To be precise, these are students who graduated from high school in the past 12 months.

Figure 11: Event-study estimates: female-to-male ratio of total full-time undergraduate enrollment

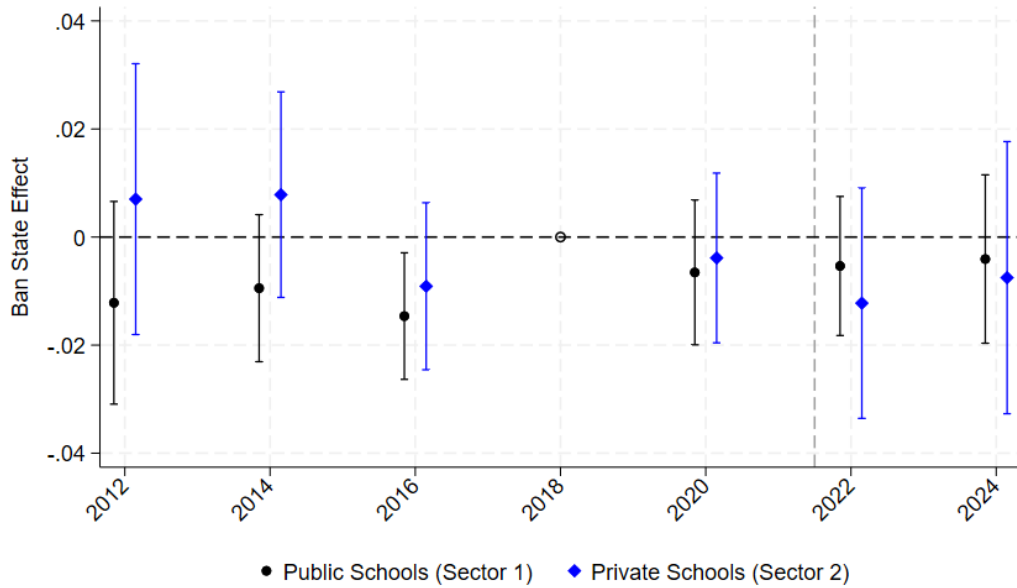


Notes: Specification as in Figure 2. The balanced reporting requirement leaves 389 public and 505 private institutions in the female-to-male full-time undergraduate ratio regressions.

of students coming from never ban states, ban states, or (our intermediate category) abortion “hostile” states. As stated earlier, schools’ reporting of this variable is only compulsory for even years. This means that odd years (2011, 2013, ..., 2023) witness a tremendous amount of missingness and we respond to this problem by dropping odd years and using 2018 as the reference year in our event study specifications. Due to these issues, we interpret the following results with hesitation.

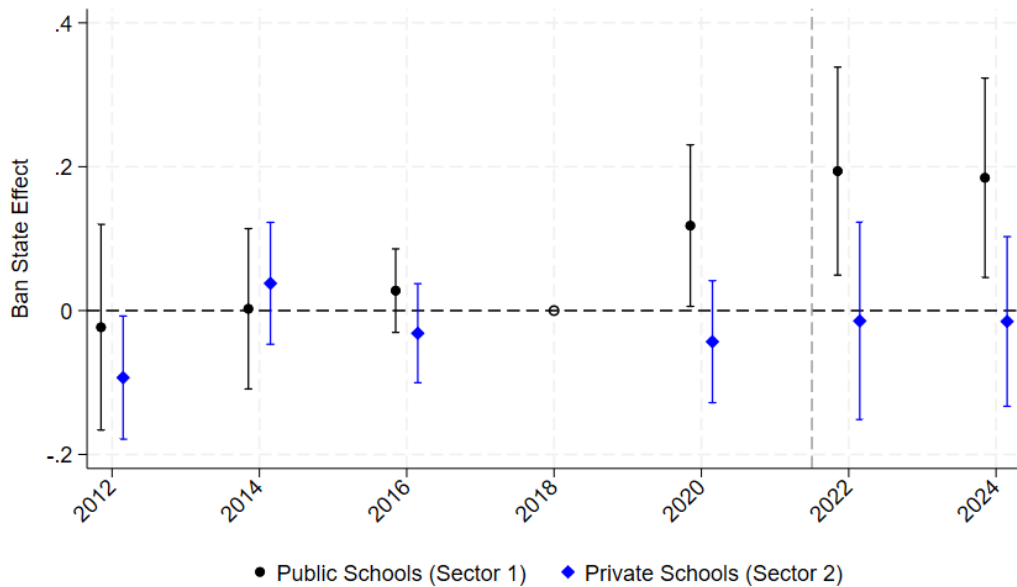
Figure 12 shows the impact of *Dobbs* on the share [0,1] of students originating from states other than the institution’s. This figure suggests that state-wide abortion bans did not affect their constituent institutions’ out-of-state enrollment outcomes on average. Figure 13, Figure 14, Figure 15 ask a deeper question: “Was there a change in the ‘type’ of state that these students come from?” For public schools, it appears that the answer is “Yes.” It does appear that these schools saw a 20 percent increase in the number of students from those states that did not ban abortion, a 24 percent decline in the number of students from those states that did ban abortion, and a 8 or 9 percent increase in the number of students from those states that are considered hostile to abortion access. For private schools, although we do estimate a statistically significant decline in the number of students originating from states that will ban abortion, the persistence of statistically significant difference pre-*Dobbs* appear to suggest that we cannot interpret those results as causal.

Figure 12: Event-study estimates: out-of-state share of first-time, full-time enrollment (US-only)



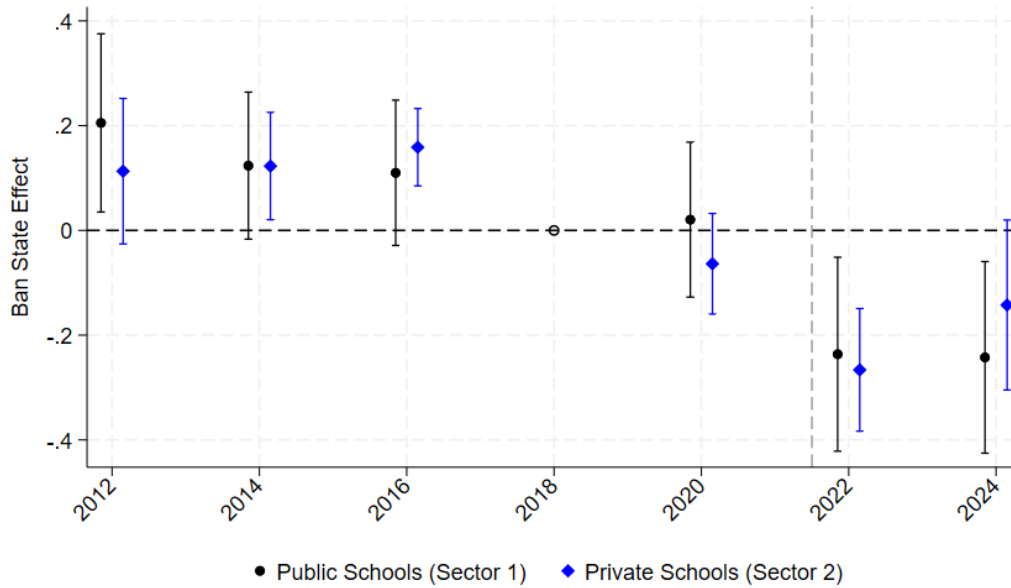
Notes: Even-year-balanced sample with 2018 as the reference year. Other specification details as in Figure 2. The even-year balanced reporting requirement leaves 389 public and 505 private institutions in the out-of-state share of freshman enrollment regressions. Imposing balanced reporting in every year (including odd years, when EFRES02 reporting is not compulsory for IPEDS institutions) would reduce the sample to 187 public and 98 private institutions.

Figure 13: Event-study estimates: log enrollment of first-time students originating from never-ban states



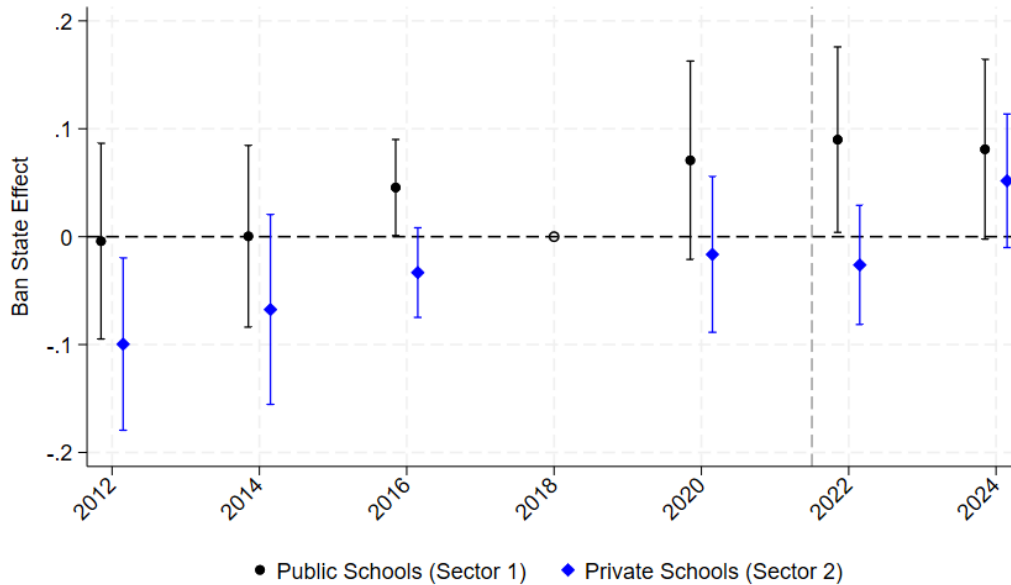
Notes: Even-year-balanced sample with 2018 as the reference year. Other specification details as in Figure 2. The even-year balanced reporting requirement leaves 389 public and 505 private institutions in the regressions for enrollment of first-time students originating from never-ban states. Imposing balanced reporting in every year (including odd years, when EFRES02 reporting is not compulsory for IPEDS institutions) would reduce the sample to 187 public and 98 private institutions.

Figure 14: Event-study estimates: log enrollment of first-time students originating from persistent-ban states



Notes: Even-year-balanced sample with 2018 as the reference year. Other specification details as in Figure 2. The even-year balanced reporting requirement leaves 389 public and 505 private institutions in the regressions for enrollment of first-time students originating from persistent-ban states. Imposing balanced reporting in every year (including odd years, when EFRES02 reporting is not compulsory for IPEDS institutions) would reduce the sample to 187 public and 98 private institutions.

Figure 15: Event-study estimates: log enrollment of first-time students originating from hostile states

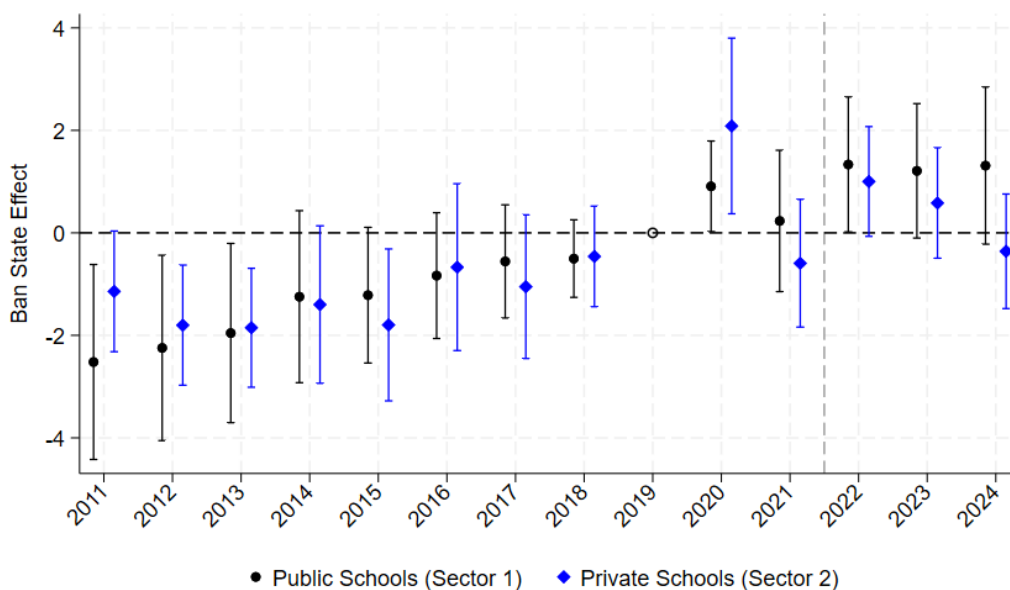


Notes: Even-year-balanced sample with 2018 as the reference year. Other specification details as in Figure 2. The even-year balanced reporting requirement leaves 389 public and 505 private institutions in the regressions for enrollment of first-time students originating from hostile states. Imposing balanced reporting in every year (including odd years, when EFRES02 reporting is not compulsory for IPEDS institutions) would reduce the sample to 187 public and 98 private institutions.

6.4 Retention, Tuition, and Housing Costs

Another margin by which *Dobbs* could impact schools is through the full-time, first-time retention rate.¹³ In Figure 16, full-time, first-time cohort retention at public institutions in ban states rises by about 1.3 percentage points for each year 2022–2024 (Figure 16), with positive and statistically significant (at a 10% level) coefficients in 2022 and 2023. Notably, the pre-period coefficients are negative through 2018 and statistically significant in some of the earlier years for both sectors, which complicates a clean parallel-trends interpretation. We present this as descriptive: retention at treated public institutions sits above its 2019 baseline in the post-period, but we are not confident the pre-trends are flat enough to attribute the lift to *Dobbs v. Jackson Women’s Health Organization*. The story is similar, but noisier for private schools where we do recover negative, but statistically insignificant point estimates in the post-period.

Figure 16: Event-study estimates: full-time cohort retention rate



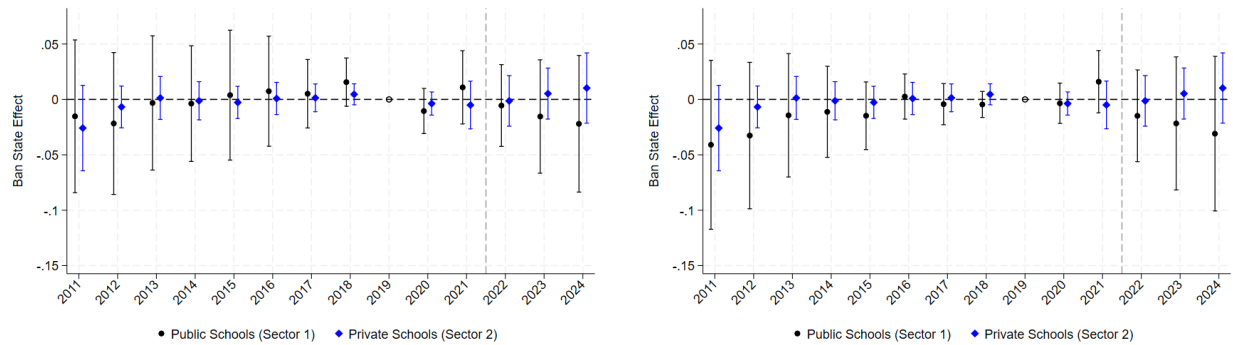
Notes: The dependent variable is the full-time cohort retention rate (RET_PCF). Specification as in Figure 2. The balanced reporting requirement leaves 371 public and 501 private institutions in the retention rate regressions.

Given the variance in tuition rates for public and private schools and between ban and non-ban states, we report the estimated effects of the post-*Dobbs* abortion bans on the log of out-of-state and in-state tuition in Figure 17. Importantly, because there is much less price discrimination based on origin residence for private schools, and these rates are typically identical in the IPEDS reports, we interpret private schools as having a single tuition. Public schools, on the other hand, receive substantial subsidies from the state or local government to promote the schooling outcomes of their constituency, driving the in-state tuition far

¹³This full-time, first-time retention rate is the percent of the prior-fall full-time, first-time cohort (after removing allowable exclusions) that re-enrolled at the institution as either full- or part-time in the current year. Exclusions are the number of students from the prior year cohort who left the institution for any of the following reasons: Died or were totally and permanently disabled; Serve in the armed forces (including those called to active duty); Serve with a foreign aid service of the Federal Government (e.g., Peace Corps); or Serve on official church missions.

below out-of-state tuition.¹⁴ We find no detectable impact to either the in-state or out-of-state tuition rates for public schools in ban states or the overall tuition rate for private schools in the same states. This is suggestive evidence that universities (especially private schools with more discretion over this variable), did not respond to abortion bans via their prices.

Figure 17: Event-study estimates: log out-of-state and in-state tuition



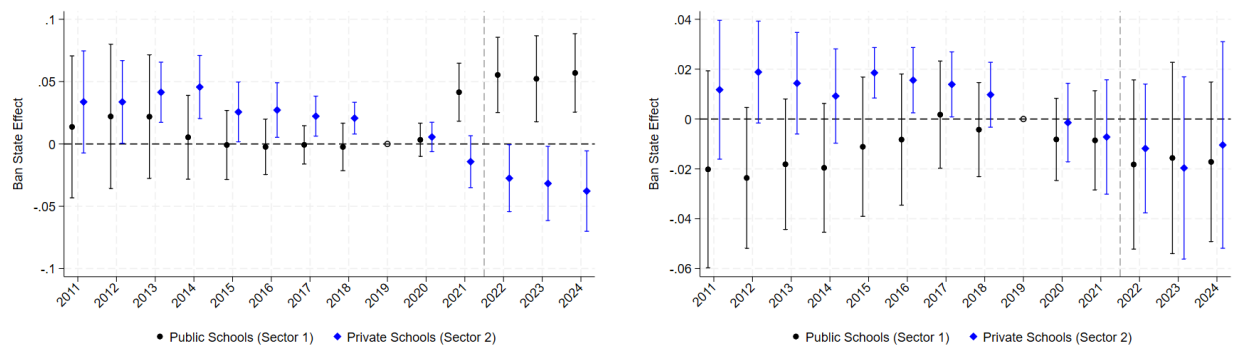
(a) Log of out-of-state tuition

(b) Log of in-state tuition

Notes: Specification as in Figure 2. The balanced reporting requirement leaves 385 public and 504 private institutions in the tuition rate regressions. Dollar values converted to their 2024 equivalent.

In Figure 18, we attempt to detect any impact of the post-*Dobbs* abortion restrictions on the log of posted room and board fees. Once again, we choose to evaluate the log of these values given the variance of these variables within and across sectors. Although we detect a 5 percent increase in the room fees for students at public institutions, we note that it appears this effect originated in 2021, which would make the attribution of these changes hard to disentangle between the a Covid-related and Dobbs-related effect.

Figure 18: Event-study estimates: log room and board fees



(a) Log of room fee

(b) Log of board fee

Notes: Specification as in Figure 2. The balanced reporting requirement leaves 252 public and 323 private institutions in the room charge regressions and 242 public and 318 private institutions in the board charge regressions. Dollar values converted to their 2024 equivalent.

¹⁴For 2019, in-state tuition was (on average) fifty percent of the reported out-of-state tuition rate for public schools.

7 Robustness and Mechanism

8 Discussion and Conclusion

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A Additional Tables and Figures

B Variable Construction Details

C State-by-State Treatment Coding

Table 3: State Classification by Post-Dobbs Abortion Ban Status

Never Ban (N=23)	Ban 2022-2024 (N=13)	Impersistent Ban or Hostile (N=13)
California	Alabama	Arizona
Colorado	Arkansas	Florida
Connecticut	Georgia	Indiana
Delaware	Idaho	Iowa
District Of Columbia	Kentucky	Nebraska
Illinois	Louisiana	North Carolina
Kansas	Mississippi	North Dakota
Maine	Missouri	Ohio
Maryland	Oklahoma	Pennsylvania
Massachusetts	South Dakota	South Carolina
Michigan	Tennessee	Utah
Minnesota	Texas	Wisconsin
Montana	West Virginia	Wyoming
Nevada		
New Hampshire		
New Jersey		
New Mexico		
New York		
Oregon		
Rhode Island		
Vermont		
Virginia		
Washington		